

Server Onboarding Specialist

25 Interview Questions & Answers - English Study Notes

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1. What is server onboarding?

Server onboarding is taking a newly installed/racked physical server and preparing it for production. Typical steps include hardware validation, BMC/IPMI setup, BIOS/storage checks, OS provisioning, configuration,

network/health validation, inventory updates, documentation, and production handoff.

Hardware → BMC/BIOS/Storage → OS → Configuration → Validation → Documentation → Production

2. What is a bare-metal server?

A bare-metal server is a physical server that uses the physical hardware directly rather than being a VM running on another host. Examples include Dell PowerEdge and HP ProLiant servers.

3. What is BMC?

BMC means **Baseboard Management Controller**. It is a dedicated controller that allows remote hardware monitoring and management independently of the operating system. It can provide power control, health/sensor information, alerts, and remote console access.

4. What is IPMI?

IPMI means **Intelligent Platform Management Interface**. It is a standard/interface used for out-of-band server management such as power control, sensor monitoring, and hardware status.

5. iDRAC vs iLO vs BMC vs IPMI

- **BMC**: server management controller
- **IPMI**: management standard/interface
- **iDRAC**: Dell remote server management
- **iLO**: HPE/HP remote server management

Easy memory: Dell → iDRAC | HPE → iLO

6. Why is out-of-band management important?

It lets administrators manage a server even when Linux is down or unreachable. For example, I can use iDRAC/iLO to inspect hardware health, access the console, view alerts, or power-cycle a server.

7. What would you check on a newly racked server?

Follow the company runbook. Typical checks: 1. Server identity/inventory
2. Power and hardware health 3. BMC/iDRAC/iLO connectivity 4. BIOS settings 5. Disks and RAID/JBOD 6. Firmware 7. NIC/network connectivity

8. Approved OS provisioning 9. Configuration 10. Health/connectivity validation 11. Inventory/documentation 12. Production handoff

8. What is RAID?

RAID means **Redundant Array of Independent Disks**. It combines disks for performance, redundancy, or both depending on the RAID level.

9. RAID 0 vs RAID 1 vs RAID 5 vs RAID 10

RAID Main idea Redundancy

RAID 0 Striping No

RAID 1 Mirroring Yes

RAID 5 Striping + single parity Yes

RAID 10 Mirroring + striping Yes

10. What is JBOD?

JBOD means **Just a Bunch Of Disks**. Instead of combining disks into a traditional RAID array, disks can be presented individually to the OS or software/storage layer.

11. What is firmware?

Firmware is low-level software stored in hardware. Server firmware can include BIOS/UEFI, BMC/iDRAC/iLO, RAID-controller, NIC, and drive firmware. Updates may address bugs, security, compatibility, or stability.

12. What is BIOS?

BIOS is firmware that initializes hardware and begins the boot process. During onboarding, settings such as boot order, network/PXE boot, CPU options, virtualization, and storage/controller configuration may be checked.

13. What is PXE boot?

PXE means **Preboot Execution Environment**. It allows a server to begin a boot or OS installation process over the network.

Power on → PXE/network boot → DHCP → Boot files → Installer/Image → OS provisioning

Interview honesty: Understand the concept, but do not claim direct production PXE experience unless you have actually performed it.

14. Server cannot PXE boot --- what do you check?

Check hardware/power, network link, correct NIC, BIOS boot order, PXE enablement, DHCP, VLAN/network configuration, boot services/files, and compare against a known-good server. Review the runbook/logs before escalation.

15. What is DHCP?

DHCP means **Dynamic Host Configuration Protocol**. It can provide IP address, subnet/prefix, default gateway, and DNS settings automatically. It can also participate in PXE workflows.

16. What is a VLAN?

VLAN means **Virtual Local Area Network**. It logically separates devices into different Layer 2 broadcast domains even when they share physical switching infrastructure.

17. IPv4 vs IPv6

IPv4 uses 32-bit addresses, for example 192.168.1.10. IPv6 uses 128-bit addresses and provides a much larger address space.

18. A newly provisioned Linux server is unreachable. How do you troubleshoot?

Work layer by layer: 1. Check BMC/power 2. Confirm Linux booted 3. Check NIC/link 4. Check IP 5. Check routes/default gateway 6. Verify VLAN/network assignment 7. Test connectivity 8. Check firewall 9. Check DNS if relevant 10. Review logs and document findings

Useful commands:

```
ip link
ip addr
ip route
ping <gateway>
ss -tulpn
journalctl
dmesg
```

19. How do you check disk information on Linux?

```
lsblk  
blkid  
df -h  
fdisk -l
```

lsblk shows block devices; blkid shows filesystem/UUID information;
df -h shows mounted filesystem usage; fdisk -l displays
disk/partition information.

20. Hardware problem vs OS problem?

First inspect BMC/iDRAC/iLO for hardware alerts, sensors,
disk/controller state, memory errors, or failed components. If hardware
appears healthy, investigate Linux boot/kernel messages, services,
filesystems, networking, CPU/memory, and logs.

21. What is a DOA server?

DOA means **Dead on Arrival**. A newly delivered server/component may
fail initial validation. Document the failure, collect hardware/error
information, and follow the repair/replacement or RMA escalation
procedure.

22. What is configuration management?

Configuration management keeps systems in a consistent desired state
using standardized processes/tools such as Ansible or Puppet.

Your interview answer:\

"My stronger hands-on experience is with Ansible and Ansible Tower
rather than Puppet. I understand configuration-management concepts and I
am comfortable learning, running, and troubleshooting established Puppet
automation."

23. What if an automation job fails during onboarding?

Do not blindly rerun it. Identify the failed task, read errors/logs,
check connectivity, credentials, configuration, package/repository
dependencies, hardware/network dependencies, fix the underlying issue
according to the runbook, rerun the approved process, validate, and
document.

24. How do you handle many servers waiting for onboarding?

Follow established priorities/workflows, maintain accurate status and inventory, use approved automation, separate successful systems from blocked ones, document/escalate blockers, and continue other approved work when possible. The goal is to keep the pipeline moving without sacrificing validation.

25. Why are you a good fit?

"My background combines Linux system administration with hands-on server and infrastructure support. I have worked with RHEL/CentOS environments and have experience with Dell PowerEdge and HP ProLiant hardware, iDRAC/iLO, RAID, firmware, bare-metal systems, Linux troubleshooting, networking, Bash, and Ansible.

I also have enterprise production-support experience, so I am comfortable following procedures, troubleshooting systematically, documenting issues, and coordinating with technical teams.

My direct hands-on experience with technologies such as Puppet and PXE-based provisioning is more limited. My stronger automation background is Ansible, but I understand the underlying concepts and I am comfortable learning the organization's established tools and runbooks."

Quick Revision Sheet

- BMC = Baseboard Management Controller
- IPMI = Intelligent Platform Management Interface
- iDRAC = Dell remote server management
- iLO = HPE remote server management
- RAID = Redundant Array of Independent Disks
- JBOD = Just a Bunch Of Disks
- PXE = Preboot Execution Environment
- DHCP = Dynamic Host Configuration Protocol
- VLAN = Virtual Local Area Network
- DOA = Dead on Arrival
- RMA = Return Merchandise Authorization

Core Onboarding Flow

Physical Server → BMC/iDRAC/iLO → BIOS/Firmware → RAID/JBOD → Network/PXE → Linux → Configuration Management → Validation → Inventory/Documentation → Production

Troubleshooting Pattern

Confirm → Hardware → OS → Network → Configuration/Automation → Logs → Fix/Escalate → Validate → Document

Study tip: Do not memorize every answer word-for-word. Understand the flow and explain it naturally.